jobs to absorb the millions who enter the labour market every year.

However, despite all challenges, Modi seems to have won the perception battle on this front. Close to 54 per cent of the respondents in the INDIA TODAY-CVoter Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll believe the Centre's steering of the economy to be outstanding or good. This was over 6 percentage points higher than the outcome in the August 2022 edition of the survey. Among the key reasons for this could be the social schemes announced during the pandemic, including the free food programme, and the succour to micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) in the form of government-guaranteed loans and other initiatives. But 27.6 per cent of the respondents also gave a "poor or very poor" assessment of the government's performance, and the remainder were non-committal. When asked whose handling of the economy is better—Manmohan Singh's UPA government or Modi—close to 51 per cent of the respondents gave the honour to Modi, and only 36.2 per cent voted in Singh's favour.

Popular perception, however, is divided on the question of the economic status of the respondents. As many as 35.2 per cent of those polled say their economic status has deteriorated under the NDA regime, while 33.3 believe it has improved. The latter are 6 percentage points higher than the August 2022 response. A good number—27.7 per cent—also say their economic status has been stable across both governments. This number is lower than the 31.2 per cent who felt so in the previous MOTN.

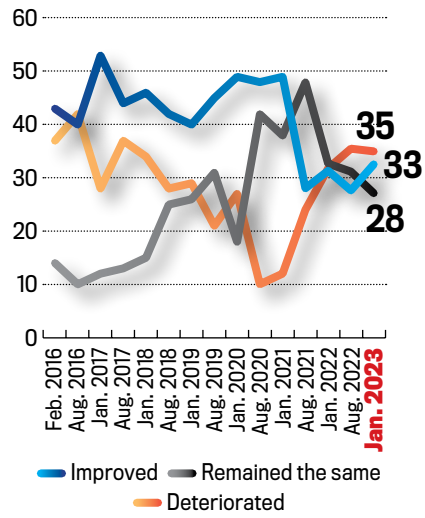
Around 31 per cent place their bets on the Indian economy improving in the next six months. This is a marginal improvement from the previous MOTN, but way behind the optimism of two years ago, when 41 per cent of the respondents believed that the economy will improve in the following six months. In the latest MOTN survey, almost an equal number, or 31.4 per cent, give a thumbs down to the economy's prospects in the next half year, a decline from the 34.2 per cent who felt so in the previous MOTN. The number of respondents who feel things will remain the same also rose to nearly 28 per cent, from 23 per cent in August 2022.

Experts, too, are erring on the side of caution when it comes to predicting the economy's future growth. Crisil, for instance, has said the economy will slacken in the second half of the current fiscal due to the base effect as well as the adverse impact of slowing global growth. According to D.K. Joshi, chief economist at the rating agency, India's growth cycles are becoming synchronous with those of the advanced economies since the 2000s due to the enhanced integration of trade and capital flows. "While domestic demand has stayed relatively resilient so far, it will be tested next year by weakening industrial activity. It will feel the pressure from increasing transmission of interest rate hikes to consumers as well, and as the catch-up in contact-based services fades," Joshi said. Crisil estimates that the country's GDP is likely to slow down to 6 per cent next fiscal.

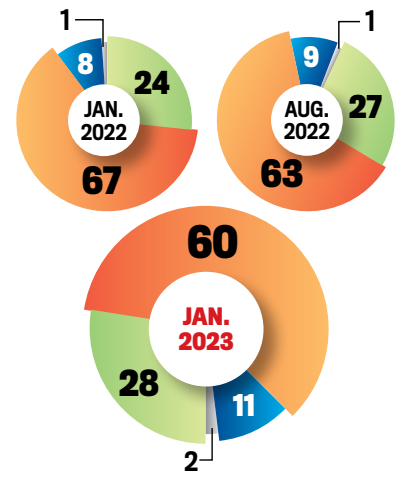
Where are the jobs?

Among the areas of utmost concern for the Modi government is the jobs situation in the country. An estimated 12 million people join the workforce every year, but there are not enough jobs for them. The Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) recorded the unemployment rate at 8.3 per cent in December, the highest since the pandemic-induced lockdown upended businesses. Although the country has come out of the pandemic, investment in new projects is yet to make a big comeback as consumer demand continues to lag. Spending on new projects slowed down for a second consecu-

Q HOW HAS YOUR ECONOMIC STATUS CHANGED SINCE NARENDRA MODI TOOK OVER AS PRIME MINISTER?



Q HOW DO YOUR CURRENT DAILY EXPENSES COMPARE WITH LAST YEAR'S?



All figures in % and rounded off;
DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say